

Bo 5783

In חשך, we read about the מכות. Let's focus on מכה number nine, חשך. The פסוק says (10:21): וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה נִטָּה יָדְךָ עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיְהִי חָשֶׁךְ עַל אֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם: (10:21). There's a pattern in the מכות, for some of them פרעה got a התראה but for חשך he did not. Hashem said to משה, "Let there be חשך" (10:22): וַיֵּט מֹשֶׁה אֶת יָדוֹ עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיְהִי חָשֶׁךְ אֲפֹלָה בְּכָל אֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם שְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים. This darkness was unlike any other, it was so intense and thick that it's described as (10:23): כָּל לַיְלָה בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל הָיָה אֹר בְּמוֹשְׁבֹתָם, but - The Egyptians were frozen in place for three days. However, בני ישראל had אור. Not only that, we know from the מדרש that they were able to travel through all the houses of מצרים to take a look at all their goodies so when it came time to borrow all of the כלים, the מצריים said, "We don't have anything", and בני ישראל were able to respond, "Actually, you do, it's in the closet, third drawer on the left." They knew exactly where it was because they were able to look around the מצריים's houses during חשך. So this was a חשך that only affected the מצריים, but not בני ישראל.

The חידושי הר"ם, the Gerrer Rebbe, offers a profound insight into the phrase חשך הגדול ביותר - What is the greatest חשך that we experience in our lives in עולם הזה?

לֹא רָאוּ אִישׁ אֶת אָחִיו - כַּאֲשֶׁר אִישׁ אֵינוֹ רוֹצֵה לִרְאוֹת אֶת אָחִיו בְּצָעְרוֹ וְלִהְיוֹשִׁיט לוֹ עֲזָרָה

This pasuk is a מוסר statement. What is the greatest חשך? חשך - לא ראו איש את אחיו - if you don't see your friend when he's having difficulty, he's having his own חשך, and as a result you don't extend him a helping hand, that is the greatest חשך. What's going to happen to someone who acts this way, ignoring his friend's plight? What will be the result? הַתּוֹצָאָה הִיא, שְׂכַאֲשֶׁר אָדָם מְתַעֵלֵם מִדַּחֲקוֹ - When a person ignores and totally is uninterested in his friend's difficulty; שָׁל חֲבֵרוֹ - When a person ignores and totally is uninterested in his friend's difficulty; מִידָה כְּנֶגֶד מִידָה - אין הוא עצמו יכול למוֹשׁ מִמְּקוֹמוֹ; he himself, will not be able to help himself. He'll have his own צָרוֹת, and he'll be stricken with exactly the same issues. He will have a problem, and nobody will help him, וְלֹא קָמוּ אִישׁ מִתַּחֲתָיו. When we see anybody having difficulty, we should extend a hand, and help in whatever way we can.

The day that I'm recording this is the תִּיִּרָה בְּרִידֵעֵר שלושִׁים, and that's exactly who he was, a man who always ran to help people at all times.

